

The Compaignye of the Pilgrim Souldiours Inc.

By-law No. 1: Harnischfechten & Intergroup Combat Regulations

Adopted pursuant to Rule 42 of the Association Constitution.

Section 1: Introduction & Scope

1. **Purpose:** This by-law sets out the rules, standards, and operational safety protocols for *Harnischfechten* (armoured combat) and intergroup combat within **The Compaignye of the Pilgrim Souldiours Inc.** (*Societas Militum Peregrinorum*).
2. **Historical Scope:** All combat representation, armour, and weapon configurations must align with our core historical focus of late medieval England between **1375 and 1425 AD**.
3. **Safety Paramount:** The intention of Harnischfechten is to reproduce historically accurate fighting in historically accurate armour safely. **Safety shall always supersede absolute historical accuracy**, with the balance determined at the sole discretion of the Group Marshal.

Section 2: Armour Standards & Categories

Combatants must present armour befitting the 1375–1425 period that fits well, functions safely, and is meticulously maintained. Rusty steel or degraded equipment is prohibited.

1. Armour Categories

- **Unproved / Unprotected:** Includes soft leather, lightly padded cloth, or unpadded garments, as well as perforated steel plate (such as fencing masks). Any blow struck against an unprotected target is a valid fair blow.
- **Light Armor:** Comprises mail (the default standard), properly hardened leather, or well-constructed padded garments. Unless specified otherwise, Light Armor is proof against cuts but vulnerable to thrusts.
- **Heavy Armor:** Comprises steel or iron plate (hardened or unhardened), or small plates properly overlapped. Heavy Armor is proof against most direct percussive blows.

2. Specific Armour Requirements

- **Throat and Neck Protection:** Must feature either stiff leather and chainmail standard/gorget, a hidden solid plate throat, a padded mail aventail, or a fully enclosed helm (such as a Great Bascinet or Armet). Kettles or bascinets with a bevor must be fixed to prevent weapon penetration at the joins.
- **Face and Head Protection:** Face plates must fully enclose the face to prevent weapon edge or point penetration.
 - Where percussion weapons are permitted, helmets must be constructed from a minimum of **2mm mild steel** (or historical equivalent); otherwise, the minimum thickness is **1.5mm**.

- **Gambesons:** When worn as primary protection without plate or mail, gambesons must be no less than **12mm thick**, and at least **8mm thick** if worn under non-rigid armour. They must adequately protect the torso, armpits, shoulders, and groin.

Section 3: Weapons & Armour Interaction (Fair Blows)

Bouts generally target between **three (3) and five (5) "fair blows"** to simulate combat damage before a participant is disabled.

1. Defining a Fair Blow

- A fair blow requires both proper technical form and controlled intent, delivered as though attempting to overcome or penetrate the opponent's defensive harness.
- **Controlled Force:** Strikes must be pulled. Full-force, uncontrolled impacts or striking rigid plate armour recklessly with unconditioned force are prohibited.

2. Weapon Efficacy Reference Matrix

Weapon	Attack Type	Unprotected	Light Armor	Heavy Armor	Notes
Dagger	Thrust / Cut	Yes	Yes (Thrust only)	No	Point must meet minimum tip dimensions.
Sword	Thrust / Cut / Handle	Yes	Yes	No (Cuts) / Yes (Half-sword/Thrusts to gaps)	Pommel and crossguard strikes permitted against light/unprotected areas.
Spear / Polearm	Thrust / Cut / Shaft	Yes	Yes	Yes (Select thrusts to gaps / heavy percussive impact)	Both hands must maintain proper control spacing.
Percussion (Poleaxe, Mace, Hammer)	Thrust / Blow / Shaft	Yes	Yes	Yes	Designed to defeat heavy plate via concussive shock and hook/spike applications.

Section 4: Off-Target Areas & Prohibited Actions

To preserve safety during late medieval harness fighting, strict boundaries govern target zones:

1. **Absolute Prohibitions:** Intentional thrusts, blows, or cuts directed at the **face, neck, spine, groin, kidneys, elbows, knees, hands, or feet** are strictly forbidden unless specifically authorized under a controlled, pre-vetted tournament ruleset with appropriate rigid face and joint protection.
2. **Consequences:** Any intentional attack to an off-target area will result in immediate removal from the field and referral to the Group Marshal for disciplinary review.

Section 5: Marshalate & Governance

1. **Group Marshal:** Responsible for overseeing training safety, authorizing individual arms and armour for authenticity and safety standards, and establishing local event requirements.
2. **Senior Marshal:** Nominated to run specific events, oversee pre-fight briefs and equipment inspections, and manage field safety.
3. **The Marshal's Authority:** *The Marshal is always right.* On the field, a marshal's safety or ruling decision is final and immediate. The primary safety call is **"HOLD"**, at which all combat must cease instantly, and participants must take a knee.
4. **Ratio:** A minimum ratio of **1 Marshal to 4 combatants** must be maintained during formal activities.

Section 6: Post-Brief & Conclave

1. Immediately following every formal combat event, participants and officials shall assemble for a post-fight debrief to address concerns, review safety, and build fraternal rapport.
2. In keeping with chivalric tradition, combatants shall determine who among them best displayed fidelity to the ideals of the deed of arms, recognizing that individual as **"First Among Equals"** for the day.